

"THE BROTHERS" AND THE
ENGLISH *COMTE DE GABALIS*

by

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Comte de Gabalis is a short novel in the form of five discourses, published anonymously in 1670 and certainly authored by the Abbé Nicolas de Montfaucon de Villars (1635?-1673).¹ Anglophone readers are most likely to find it in a translation first published in 1913 and often reprinted.² Attributed only to "The Brothers," it carries a pseudo-scholarly commentary every verso page and on 145 pages at the end, in which Villars' lively and satirical text is treated as a solemn source of esoteric teachings. Who were these Brothers? This article seeks to answer that question and to illuminate an enigmatic episode in *Gabalis*' reception history.

Villars' novel was an instant success. It was soon banned in France, reprinted in Holland and Cologne, and supplied with spurious sequels. Two different English translations appeared in 1680, inspiring Alexander Pope in his *Rape of the Lock* (1712), and a third soon afterwards.³ Pope's mock epic introduced English readers, as Villars had the French, to the picturesque realm of the elementals: sylphs, salamanders, undines or nymphs, and gnomes. Gabalis, a German count, claims deep knowledge of them and their habits, as well as of Kabbalah, alchemy, and occult mysteries. He urges the sceptical narrator to renounce human women and to marry a sylph, adding that the greatest ones of the past were all the result of such inter-species intercourse.

The 1913 translation is accurate, if ponderous, and omits Villars' more salacious passages. The Brothers are named as publisher and copyright holder, and leave us to draw our own conclusions from their oval emblem (figure 1), which appears insistently: twice on the dust jacket, twice embossed on the cover, and four more times inside the book.

1. The best scholarly edition, exactly transcribing the 1670 print, is Montfaucon de Villars, *Le Comte de Gabalis; La Critique de Bérénice*, Introduction et Commentaire par Roger Laufer (Paris: A. G. Nizet, 1963).

2. The title page reads: *Comte de Gabalis / by the / Abbé N. de Montfaucon de Villars / Rendered out of French into English / with a Commentary.* / "When a thing is hidden away with so much pains, / merely to reveal it is to destroy it." Tertullian / Published by The Brothers / [symbol] / and printed at The Old Bourne Press, / under the supervision of W. H. Broome, / 15 Holborn, London, EC. / Copyright, The Brothers, 1913.

3. *The Count of Gabalis: or Conferences about Secret Sciences* (London: for Robert Harford, 1680); *The Count of Gabalis, or, The Extravagant Mysteries of the Cabalists* (London: for B.M., Printer to the Cabalistical Society of the Sages, at the Sign of the Rosy-Crucian, 1680); *The Count of Gabalis, Being a Diverting History of the Rosicrucian Doctrine of Spirits* (London: for B. Lintott & E. Curll, 1714).

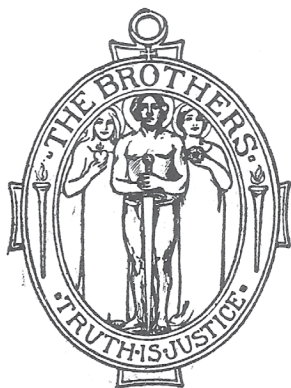


FIGURE 1. Emblem of The Brothers.

The printer was the Old Bourne Press, a private press founded in London in 1902 by W. Herbert Broome that produced illustrated books in limited editions. *Comte de Gabalis* fits the profile of a private commission, using the resources of Broome's workshop. It is richly illustrated in line, sepia, and photogravure. The unsigned decorations are typical of the Symbolist period of the late nineteenth century, such as the chapter heading (figure 2) which shows the four types of elementals gathered around a philosophical family. The initial letter on page 274 (figure 3) is copied, line by line, from Elihu Vedder's famous painting *The Questioner of the Sphinx* (the lesser-known version of 1875, in semi-profile). Other illustrations are taken with due acknowledgment from museums.

There is only one reference to The Brothers in the body of the book, and it is a teasing one. The photograph opposite p. 297 of a half-length, turbaned figure is captioned: "Portrait of a Master. Painted by R. Owned by The Brothers." It is visibly an "old master" oil painting with a crackled surface. Since Rembrandt's *Polish Rider* (now in the Frick Collection, New York) is the only other painting reproduced in the book, and the artist was known for his love of Oriental costume, the reader is free—perhaps even invited—to imagine The Brothers as custodians of priceless art treasures.

Examples of this edition are sometimes seen with the imprint of William Rider & Son, the London publisher of much occult literature, and the date 1922. A new title page has been pasted in, reading: "Comte de Gabalis. *Discourses on the Secret Sciences and Mysteries, in accordance with the principles of the Ancient Magi and the Wisdom of the Kabalistic Philosophers.* By the Abbé N. de Montfaucon de Villars. Newly rendered into English with Commentary and Annotations." A catalogue entry of Weiser Antiquarian Books comments: "We can only presume that Rider took over the already bound stock of books from 'The Brothers' and had a new title-page printed and inserted, and (perhaps later) a dust jacket printed."⁴ This

4. I am grateful to Keith Richmond of Weiser Antiquarian Books from bringing this to my attention.



DISCOURSE IV.



AWAITED the Comte de Gabalis at my house, as we had arranged at parting. He came at the appointed hour, and accosting me with a smiling air, said, "Ah, well, my Son, which of the Invisible Peoples does God

FIGURE 2. *Comte de Gabalis* (1913), p. 115.

EVIATHAN. JOB xl, 1.—Canst thou draw out leviathan with an hook?

The word Leviathan in Hebrew is made up of two roots, Levi and Than. "ThN, Than, which is the root of Serpent or

FIGURE 3. *Comte de Gabalis* (1913), p. 274.

variant is identical to the 1913 edition in every respect except that there is no copyright line.

The true second edition appeared in New York, 1914, identical to the first in binding, format, font, and design. However, the text has been reset, so that the pagination differs by a few lines, and the italics and capitals are different. The commentaries lack the London edition's identifying letters, from A to HHH. A few footnotes are added. If there was a dust jacket, I have not seen it. The obverse of the half-title names "New York / Harry B. Haines, 527 West 110th Street / London

/ W. H. Broome, 15 Holborn, E. C. / Copyright, The Brothers, 1914." On the title page: "PUBLISHED BY THE BROTHERS," and on the obverse: "COPYRIGHT 1914, / BY THE BROTHERS. / [symbol] / THE NEWS PRINTING COMPANY / PATERSON N.J." Harry B. Haines (1882-1972) was editor and publisher of the *Morning/Evening News* of Paterson, New Jersey. Evidently this edition was another private commission, executed by Haines's printer.

The third edition (New York, 1922) contains a real surprise. It was issued by a commercial house, the well-known Masonic publisher Macoy. The dust jacket carries advertisements for books by Theosophical authors (William Q. Judge, Anna Kingsford, Mabel Collins, Franz Hartmann), and the spine shows the Masonic square and compass in place of The Brothers' emblem, which now occurs only on the copyright page. The quality of production is hardly inferior to the preceding editions, except that the photographs and half-tone illustrations are in gray, not sepia, and without tissue guards. The text has again been reset and the footnotes numbered, rather than identified by symbols. The portrait by "R" is no longer said to be owned by The Brothers. The surprise is that the translation is now described as "Rendered out of French into English with a Commentary by Lotus Dudley," and "Copyright 1914, 1922 Sarah Emery Dudley." Lotus Dudley also signs a new Foreword, inserted on a formerly blank page. All this is confirmed in the U.S. *Catalogue of Copyright Entries*.⁵

Lotus and Sarah Dudley were in fact the same person, and quite conspicuous in certain circles. Sarah Lotta Emery Dudley (1878-1954) was a daughter of George Daniel Emery (1833-1909), a wealthy industrialist in Buffalo, New York.⁶ She was educated at the Cambridge School for Girls and at Bryn Mawr College.⁷ In 1904 she married Charles Tarbell Dudley, a Harvard graduate and mining engineer. They settled in San Francisco and had two children, but their marriage was short-lived, for in 1908 Charles died of tuberculosis.⁸ According to the Bryn Mawr alumnae newsletter, Sarah went to England the following year, 1909.⁹

The same newsletter announces in June 1914 that "Lotta Emery Dudley (Mrs. Charles Tarbell Dudley), has been spending several months in America. She came over to supervise the publication of *her book* [my italics]."¹⁰ This explains how the second edition of *Comte de Gabalis* appeared from its American

5. *Catalogue of Copyright Entries*, New Series, 1922, entry no. 8317 for *Comte de Gabalis* is dated May 3, 1922, under the number A 674197 and the name of "Sarah Emery Dudley, c/o Macoy Publishing & Masonic Supply Co." It adds "Copyright is claimed on the foreword, by Lotus Dudley."

6. The career of George Emery, known as the "Mahogany King," is documented in Samuel A. Eliot, *Biographical History of Massachusetts*, vol. 4 (Boston: Massachusetts Biographical Society, 1913), 114-17.

7. Information from ancestry.com.

8. Obituary of Charles Tarbell Dudley '00 in *Yale Alumni Weekly*, XVIII/7 (Nov. 11, 1908): 183.

9. "Mrs. C. T. Dudley is visiting Mary Converse '98 before sailing to England where she will spend the summer." *Bryn Mawr Alumnae Quarterly*, April 1909.

10. *Bryn Mawr Alumnae Quarterly*, July 1914. "News from the Classes. 1900." The quotation continues: "She has been the guest of the Sorosis Club, the New York Women's Press Club, and has addressed other organizations in New York and in the Middle West."

press so soon, and so faithfully to the original design. It also staked a claim for Dudley to The Brother's production, if only among her collegiate friends.

From July 1915 until 1919, Dudley directed a small private school in Greenwich, Connecticut. It was called the Wabanaki School, after the indigenous tribe of the region, and was situated next to the estate of Ernest Thompson Seton (1860-1946). He had been instrumental in founding the Boy Scouts of America and other movements favoring the free, outdoor education of the young, and had a particular admiration for the Native Americans and their culture.

So did Dudley. After she retired from the school she became a psychic or spiritual adviser, notably of the socialite and diarist Mabel Dodge Luhan (1879-1962), who knew her as "Mrs. Lotus Dudley."¹¹ In 1919 Mabel was considering settling in Taos, New Mexico, and marrying Tony Luhan, an Indian of the Tiwa tribe. Dudley assured "Mrs. Sterne" (as Mabel then was) that she (Mabel) was destined to build a bridge between Indian wisdom and the West. Taos was to be a great spiritual center, indeed the "heart of the world."¹² Due to Mabel's magnetism and wealth, the town would soon become a meeting-point of cultural celebrities.

Dudley's later career included international conferencing with influential connections.¹³ On one occasion her sense of entitlement went too far, and she spent two days in detention by the Paris police.¹⁴ In 1935 she contributed a long introduction to excerpts from the *Ramayana*, published by the London orientalist house of Luzac.¹⁵ By 1937 she appears to have become a Muslim.¹⁶ She was evidently a complex woman, whose biography would reward further research. But was the *Comte de Gabalis* really her work?

No such idea was current on the other side of the Atlantic, where the clues converged on a character known only as M. In 1927, an "occult autobiography" titled *The White Brother* appeared under the name of Michael Juste.¹⁷ It describes

11. Gale M. Harley, *Emma Curtis Hopkins: Forgotten Founder of New Thought* (Syracuse: Syracuse University Press, 2002), 105-109, on Hopkins' opposition to Dudley's influence over Mabel Luhan. See also Lois Palken Rudnick, *Intimate Memories: The Autobiography of Mabel Dodge Luhan* (Albuquerque: University of New Mexico Press, 1999), 165.

12. Seven letters from Dudley to Luhan are in the Mabel Dodge Luhan Papers, Beinecke Library, Yale University, YCAL MAA 196, Box 10, folder 274. Here quoted: letter of May 29, 1919.

13. "I attended the International Congress of Women in Vienna in May and represented the United States on the Committee of Letters, and was at the preliminary meeting at Budapest and the later conferences elsewhere. Since the end of June I have been visiting my old friend, the Duchess of Somerset, at Maiden Bradley." *Bryn Maur Bulletin*, XI/2 (Feb. 1931).

14. "Paris Frees New York Woman," *New York Evening Post*, July 17, 1933: "Mrs. Charles Tarbell Dudley of New York, who was held by police after she insisted on seeing President Labrun last Friday, was released today and left for London. She had been a resident of Paris for three years."

15. Mahatma Tulsidas, *Book of Ram, the Bible of India*, trans. Hari Prasad Shastri (London: Luzac, 1935), 7-22.

16. Lotus Dudley writes on Feb. 22, 1937 from Herne Hill, London, addressing "Dear Sir and Brother in Islam, Assalam-o-alaikum" and expressing her "steadfastness in Islam." *Islamic Review* 25 (1937): 276.

17. Michael Juste, *The White Brother: An Occult Autobiography* (London: Rider & Co., n.d. [1927]).

a group of young aspirants living a Bohemian existence in postwar Bloomsbury. Their mentor, the White Brother of the title, is an older occultist called "Brother M" who takes them on astral journeys and other adventures.

The book is actually a *roman à clef*. Michael Juste was a pseudonym of Michael Hurwitz (1897-1961), author, poet, playwright, and, under the name of Michael Houghton, founder and proprietor of the Atlantis Bookshop, which still exists (as of 2024) near the British Museum. His nephew, the eminent English violinist Emanuel Hurwitz, remembered him as "a benevolent white magician."¹⁸ Michael's friend, called "David" in the book, is securely identified as Raphael Hurst (1898-1981), who would become a best-selling author on spirituality under the name of Paul Brunton.¹⁹ Brunton's son, Kenneth Thurston Hurst (1923-2009), has confirmed that Brother M was a family friend and his own godfather (witness Kenneth's middle name). But he only knew him as Mr. Thurston, an American painter living in London and specializing in lacquer work for upscale department stores. No one hitherto had been able to identify him.

There are two further books authored simply by M and bearing The Brothers' emblem. The first was *The Dayspring of Youth* (1933), advertised by the publisher as "By One of the Brothers."²⁰ The reviewer in *Psychic Science* speculated that M "seems to be identical with Michael Juste, author of *White Brother*."²¹ It was a good guess, but missed the mark.

A second book by M, *The Lord God of Truth Within*, was compiled by Hurwitz and published in 1941 by the press of the esoteric entrepreneur Manly Palmer Hall.²² It is subtitled *A Posthumous Sequel to The Dayspring of Youth*, and includes anecdotes about sylphs and gnomes who are M's personal friends.

M mentions *Comte de Gabalis* in both books. In *Dayspring* he prefaces a long quotation with the words: "In a book previously mentioned by us, *The Comte de Gabalis*, we have written this passage about prayer . . ." (p. 326). In *The Lord God of Truth Within*, M writes: "we have spoken about [Merlin] in a former book [footnote] *Comte de Gabalis*." (p. 159) The three books form a coherent, if idiosyncratic, body of doctrine.

Yet the 1922 edition loudly claimed to be the work of Lotus Dudley. My first unpleasant suspicion was that she had appropriated Thurston's work and republished it under her own name(s). He could have been referring to this when he wrote, in the Preface to *The Dayspring of Youth*, "as certain people in the past have assumed authorship of some of my writings, all publications of the Brothers will be issued in future under their seal and copyrighted" (p. 7). But this does not accord with what is known of Dudley's character. The references to *Comte de Gabalis* in Thurston's later books, carefully read, do not claim authorship: they merely say that his words have appeared in it.

18. Riki Gerardy, *Talks with Emanuel Hurwitz: 82 Years with the Violin* (Edgware: Zelia, 2006), 11.

19. On Brunton's connections with Michael Juste and with M, see Kenneth Thurston Hurst, *Paul Brunton: A Personal View* (Burdett, NY: Larson Publications, 1989), 44-46, 60-62.

20. M, *The Dayspring of Youth* (*Yoga Practice Adapted for Western Bodies*) (London & New York: Putnam, 1933).

21. Unsigned review, *Psychic Science* 12/4 (Jan. 1934): 317.

22. M, *The Lord God of Truth Within* (Los Angeles: Phoenix Press, 1941).

By a chance that could only have happened in the era of the Internet, I came across a joint application by Thurston and Dudley for a U.S. patent.²³

Patent application filed April 15, 1913. Serial no. 761,151. Book cover. Charles W. Thurston and Sarah Emery Dudley, United States Citizens residing at London. Patent issued by the United States Patent Office, July 14, 1914, no. 1,103,102.

The application is for a book cover incorporating a slot on the inside into which a card can be inserted. The invention is trivial, but the technical drawing accompanying it (figure 4) shows the unmistakable emblem of The Brothers, just as it appears on the front paste-down of the 1913 edition of *Comte de Gabalis*. And there are the signatures of Charles W. Thurston and Sarah Emery Dudley. Simultaneously with the first edition, they had planted this clue to The Brothers' identity where no one would think of looking for it. It also revealed Thurston's first name, making it possible to track him down.²⁴ In 2021 I acquired sixteen letters written in the 1920s and 1930s to Hurwitz from Brunton, Thurston, and Thurston's wife, which supplied further biographical information on all of them.²⁵

Charles Willis Thurston (1872-1937) was born near Boston into an inventor's family. As a boy he "gathered mushrooms in Emerson's front yard"²⁶ and frequented the local Native Americans. He left a faint trail in the Boston art scene.²⁷ By 1908 he was among the host of American artists exhibiting in Paris. Thus he was almost certainly the unnamed illustrator of our edition. I do not know whether there were any other Brothers, nor who was Thurston's own master. His teachings partly resemble those of Thomas Lake Harris (1823-1906), founder of the Brotherhood of the New Life, who consorted with fairies and claimed to be married to a queen in their realm.

A tentative conclusion emerges from this: that Sarah or Lotus Dudley met Thurston in London after her husband's death. He instructed her in psychic and esoteric matters, and they collaborated on the *Comte de Gabalis*. While the occult material was Thurston's, by page-count it is in small proportion to the excerpts from classical works, quotations, summaries, supplements, and comparisons that fill out the 377 pages, not to mention the translation itself. Dudley, with her Bryn Mawr education and the British Museum at hand, was easily capable of such work. She probably financed the 1913 London edition and the New York edition of the following year. In 1922, with the earlier editions impossible to find,

23. The patent application was revealed in a YouTube talk of May 25, 2021, entitled "Who Wrote the Dayspring of Youth?" I am grateful to the presenter, identified only as "MtalksX," for this vital piece of information.

24. On his ancestry, see the Frost Genealogy (https://archive.org/stream/frostgenealogyinoofros/frostgenealogyinoofros_djvu.txt) and *Thurston Genealogies*, compiled by Brown Thurston (Portland, Maine: Compiler, 1880), 232.

25. Charles Thurston married Aileen Winifred Cook (1889 or 1890-1953) on April 30, 1921. The marriage certificate describes both as "Artist and decorator." The letters to Hurwitz will be made accessible on the website of the Paul Brunton Philosophic Foundation. See <https://www.paulbrunton.org/index.php>.

26. *The Lord God of Truth Within*, 198.

27. *The Boston Arts Club: Exhibition Record, 1873-1909*, compiled and edited Janice H. Chadbourne et al. (Madison, CT: Sound View Press, 1991), 375.

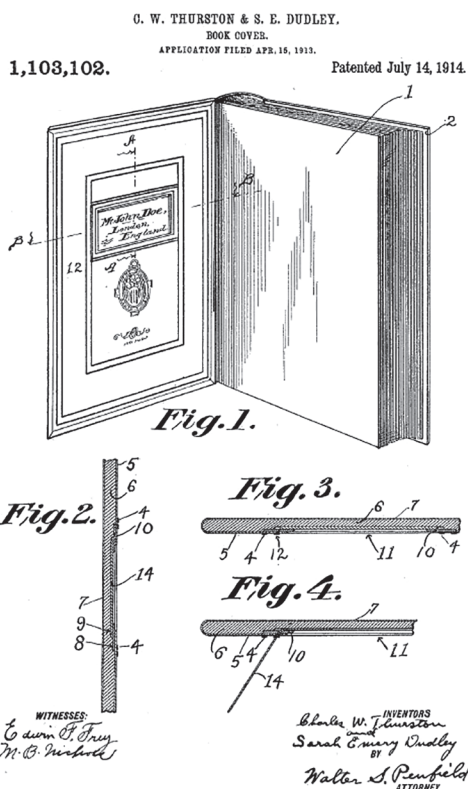


FIGURE 4. Patent granted to Charles W. Thurston and Sarah Emery Dudley (July 14, 1914).

she arranged for its new publication by a commercial publisher. This required copyrighting under an individual's legal name, so she gave her own. Since The Brothers no longer existed as a working group, there was no reason to perpetuate their mystery. If this is correct, the joint patent of a "book cover" in which names can be inserted and removed was appropriately symbolic, even prophetic.